

Research Briefing

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US–Iran ceasefire and nuclear talks 2026

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Summary

On 28 February 2026, [Israel and the United States launched air strikes against Iran](#). They said they aimed to induce regime change in the country and target its nuclear and ballistic missile programme. Iran's Supreme Leader, Ali Khamenei, was killed in the strikes. Iran responded by attacking US bases in the region, Israel, and sites in neighbouring Middle Eastern states, as well as closing the Strait of Hormuz. From Lebanon, Iran-backed Hezbollah launched attacks on Israel, which in turn launched ground operations in Lebanon.

Attacks continued across the Middle East region until 8 April, when Pakistan announced that the US and Iran had agreed a two-week pause. Israel–Hezbollah fighting continued into June and intermittent conflict between the US, Israel and Iran has also occurred. On 17 June, the US and Iran signed a 14-point memorandum of understanding (MOU). The MOU sets out plans for talks in an initial 60-day period on issues including freedom of navigation in the Strait of Hormuz, Iran's nuclear and missile programmes, and sanctions.

The Israeli/US attacks on Iran follow the failure of Oman-mediated talks in February 2026, as well as [US/Israeli strikes on Iran's nuclear sites in 2025](#).

This briefing describes negotiations in 2026, the issues under discussion, and what the involved countries would like from the talks. For information on the wider conflict in 2026, see the Commons Library collection [Iran in 2026](#).

What's in the memorandum of understanding?

No official text of the 14-point memorandum of understanding signed in June 2026 has been published, but the [text briefed to journalists](#) and the [text released by Iran](#) are similar.

Paragraph 1 states that there will be a “permanent termination of military operations on all fronts”, including between Israel and Hezbollah in Lebanon (neither they, nor the Lebanese Government, are party to the memorandum or the talks; [separate talks are being held on the Israel–Hezbollah conflict](#)). The texts also says that Iran will not have a nuclear weapon (paragraph 8).

The memorandum sets out a three-stage process. The first stage stipulates five measures that signatories must start implementing before wider talks can occur:

- the US must lift its blockade of Iranian ports (paragraph 4)
- Iran must arrange for the safe passage of ships through Hormuz (paragraph 5)

- the US must lift sanctions on Iranian oil exports (paragraph 10)
- the US and Iran must discuss the possibility of the US lifting restrictions on Iranian assets frozen abroad (paragraph 11)

As their implementation begins, the memorandum says wider discussions towards a final deal will be undertaken. Other elements to be finalised include a US\$300 billion reconstruction plan for Iran (paragraph 6), the process for lifting sanctions on Iran (paragraph 7), and the inspection of Iran’s nuclear programme and disposing enriched material (paragraph 8).

The memorandum envisages a 60-day period (extendable by mutual consent) to discuss these issues (paragraph 3). The final agreement will be endorsed by the UN Security Council (as was the 2015 nuclear agreement with Iran; paragraph 14). In 2026, the [UK, Germany and France have said they are willing to lift certain sanctions](#) against Iran under a new nuclear agreement.

US: Priorities and statements in 2026 talks

At the [start of the strikes in February 2026](#), President Trump said that the US had launched the attacks to “annihilate” the Iranian navy, destroy Iran’s missile sites and programme, and that he would not allow Iran to develop a nuclear weapon. He also called on Iranians “to take over your government” and said “[there will be no deal with Iran except unconditional surrender](#)”.

In the April 2026 talks, the US said its “[core goal](#)” was [Iran confirming that it would never seek a nuclear weapon](#). In 2025 and 2026, it has also said that [Iran must conduct “zero enrichment”](#). The [reopening of the Strait of Hormuz](#), toll-free, (as had been case before February 2026) is also a stated US priority. In June, the president says that [recovering Iran’s enriched uranium is less urgent than reopening the strait](#), and that [Iran should be allowed to maintain ballistic missiles](#) in “relative proportion” to neighbouring Gulf states. The president has said that there will be [no US state investment in Iran](#) and that [released funds will be restricted to purchasing US food and medicine](#).

Iran: Priorities and statements in 2026 talks

Iran’s supreme leader, Mojtaba Khamenei, says he has [a “different view” to that of Iran’s elected President, Mahmoud Pezeshkian, on the June memorandum](#). However, he said that President Pezeshkian had given him assurances that “the rights of the Iranian nation and the Resistance Front” (Iran-backed terrorist and armed groups like Hezbollah) would be protected in talks, and so agreed to Iran’s signing of the text.

In June, Iran has said [a ceasefire between Israel and Hezbollah in Lebanon is a precondition for wider talks](#), and reiterated that some issues, such as its [ballistic missile programme](#), are not for negotiation. [President Pezeshkian had said in March that Iran had three conditions](#) for ending the conflict: 1) “firm guarantees against future aggression”, 2) the recognition of “Iran’s legitimate rights” and 3) the payment of reparations to Iran.

Iran has also said that it wants to establish [a new regime to govern the Strait of Hormuz](#), and one of its negotiators said in June that [access to the strait will include charges](#). Oman, which has managed the strait with Iran, [opposes any tolls](#), which [the US says would be unacceptable to include in any deal](#).

What have others said about the 2026 talks?

There have been a wide range of responses to the 2026 talks.

Israel

Although Israel participated in the strikes against Iran alongside the US from 28 February 2026, it is not directly participating in the Pakistan-mediated talks. Following a conversation with President Trump, on 11 June 2026 the Israeli Prime Minister, Benjamin Netanyahu, said that [the president had told him the final agreement would have four elements](#), including removing enriched material and limits on Iranian missiles.

Several members of the ruling government in Israel and Israeli opposition leaders were critical of the memorandum. The Israeli Security Minister, Itamar Ben Gvir, said that [“Trump’s agreement does not bind us”](#).

The UK Government

The [UK Government welcomed the April 2026 talks](#) and [June 2026 agreement](#). Together with other European states, it has said that the memorandum should be implemented quickly, and that it is prepared to deploy [a defensive mission to Hormuz to secure freedom of navigation](#), once the conflict ends. The government has also said it is willing to support [“relevant” sanctions relief on Iran](#) if an agreement on curtailing its nuclear programme is reached.

Arab Gulf states

In a joint statement issued after the memorandum was signed in June 2026, the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC; Bahrain, Kuwait, Oman, Qatar, Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates) said that [“lasting regional peace” requires “addressing the full spectrum of Iran’s threats”](#). They said these include Iran’s ballistic missile programme, drones and support for armed groups overseas. The GCC also called for “free” access through Hormuz.

1 What talks have been held in 2026?

Three sets of US–Iran talks have been held in 2026, with the first pre-dating the US/Israel–Iran conflict that began on 28 February, the second in early April, and the third under the memorandum of understanding (MOU) from 17 June. The June talks, planned to last for 60 days, can be extended by mutual consent.

For information on the conflict since February 2026, including Israeli and US statements on why they launched their attacks on Iran, the Iranian blockade of the Strait of Hormuz and attacks on Israel and Arab states in response, and US blockade of Iranian ports, see the [Library’s Iran in 2026 page](#).

1.1 Oman-mediated talks, February 2026

The [Israel/US strikes on Iran from 28 February 2026](#) followed the failure of indirect talks between the US and Iran, which were mediated by Oman.

The talks themselves had followed the [October 2025 triggering of snapback sanctions against Iran](#) under the 2015 nuclear deal by the UK, Germany and France. At the time, the UK Government had backed the February 2026 talks and had called for them to continue.¹

Like later talks (see below), talks in early 2026 centred on Iran’s nuclear and ballistic programme, and the timing of any US sanctions relief. At that point, Iran did not claim control over the Strait of Hormuz.

Following the end of these talks, on 27 February, Oman’s Foreign Minister, Badr Albusaidi, who helped to mediate them, said that he was “confident” that “a peace deal is within our reach” and that there had been “substantial” progress. This included Iran agreeing to “never, ever have a nuclear material that will create a bomb”, which he said was “completely new”.²

However, President Trump had said he was “not thrilled” with the talks. The US and Israeli strikes against Iran began the next day.³

1.2 Pakistan-mediated talks, early April 2026

Following nearly six weeks of conflict, on 8 April 2026 Pakistan’s Prime Minister, Shehbaz Sharif, announced that the US and Iran had agreed a

¹ HC Deb, [17 March 2026](#), c782

² CBS News, [Full transcript: Omani Foreign Minister Badr Albusaidi](#), 27 February 2026

³ BBC News, [Trump ‘not thrilled’ with Iran](#), 27 February 2026

conditional two-week ceasefire, during which talks would be held on a lasting agreement.⁴ This ceasefire period was subsequently extended, though there was some violence before a further agreement was reached in June and again after it (see page 7 for further strikes and section 1.3 for the June agreement).

The US and Iran had exchanged short plans in April

On 7 April 2026, the US President had said that a 10-point plan presented by Iran formed a “workable basis” for talks.⁵ The plan referred to by the president was not released, but the BBC quoted Iranian state media as suggesting one 10-point plan included Iran’s right to enrich uranium and a commitment to lift all sanctions on Iran (the US had not publicly agreed to either position).⁶

The Iranian Foreign Minister, Abbas Araghchi, also released a statement from the Iranian National Security Council on 8 April, which said that future negotiations would be based on a 10-point plan by Iran and a 15-point plan by the US.⁷ The US plan has not been published, but on 24 March the BBC cited US and Israeli media reports to suggest that elements could include Iran ending all enrichment of nuclear material, limiting its missile production, and ending its support for armed groups overseas. In return, the US would support a civilian nuclear programme and lift sanctions against the country.⁸

First talks on 11 April were unsuccessful

On 11 April 2026, talks were held in the capital of Pakistan, Islamabad.

Both sides reported that progress had been made, but no agreement was reached. The US President said that “most points were agreed to, but the only point that really mattered, nuclear, was not”.⁹ He described Iran as “unyielding” on the issue.¹⁰

Iran’s Foreign Minister said an agreement was “just inches away” but criticised “maximalism, shifting goalposts, and blockade” from the US negotiators.¹¹ Iran also said that its participation was conditional on ending [the conflict between Israel and Hezbollah in Lebanon](#). One of Iran’s negotiators, Parliament Speaker Mohammed Bager Qalibaf, had said any negotiations with the US would be “unreasonable” if that conflict continued.¹²

⁴ Shebhaz Sharif on Twitter/X, “[With the greatest humility, I am pleased to announce \[...\]](#)”, 7 April 2026

⁵ President Trump on Truth Social, [Based on conversations with Prime Minister Shebhaz Sharif and Field Marshal Asim Munir \[...\]](#), 7 April 2026

⁶ BBC News, [The 10-point plan for the conditional ceasefire, according to Iran](#), 8 April 2026

⁷ Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi on Twitter/X, “[Statement \[...\]](#)”, 7 April 2026

⁸ BBC News, [What is reportedly in Trump's 15-point peace plan?](#), 24 March 2026

⁹ President Trump on Truth Social, “[So, there you have it, the meeting went well](#)”, 12 April 2026

¹⁰ President Trump on Truth Social, “[Iran promised to open the Strait of Hormuz](#)”, 12 April 2026

¹¹ Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi on Twitter/X, “[In intensive talks \[...\]](#)” 12 April 2026

¹² Reuters, Iran [says peace talks would be ‘unreasonable’ following Israeli strikes](#), 8 April 2026

Conflict continued despite April and June agreements

Despite the agreements reached in April and June 2026, there has been some armed conflict between Israel, Iran and the US, as well as fighting in Lebanon (see the separate [Commons Library briefing on the Israel–Hezbollah conflict](#)).

The Institute for the Study of War’s [Iran update provides a daily summary of violence](#) in 2026. Instances of conflict in June include:

- 2 June 2026: [Iran said it targeted US bases in the Arab Gulf](#) following US strikes on an Iranian oil tanker and Qeshm Island.
- 6 June 2026: [further Iranian missile strikes on US bases](#) followed US attacks on Iranian drones in the Strait of Hormuz. [Kuwait and Bahrain were among the states targeted by Iranian strikes](#).
- 7 June 2026: [Iran attacked Israel for the first time since the April agreement](#). Iran said it was in response to Israeli attacks on Hezbollah in Lebanon. [Israel responded with strikes in Iran](#).
- 9 June 2026: the [US said it launched a “self-defence strike” against Iran](#) in response to the downing of a US helicopter.
- 10 June 2026: the [US said it launched “additional self-defence strikes against multiple targets in Iran”](#). [Iran targeted Jordan, Bahrain and Kuwait](#). President Trump said [Iran had “taken too long to negotiate a deal”](#) and Iran [described the April agreement as “practically meaningless”](#).

On 17 June, Iran and the US said they had signed a memorandum of understanding (see section 1.3). However, there was further violence:

- 25 to 28 June 2026: on 26 June, [the US said it had conducted strikes against Iran](#) in response to an Iranian attack on commercial ship in the Strait of Hormuz. [Iran attacked US bases in Bahrain and Kuwait](#) in response to continuing US attacks, which the US said were [in reaction to further Iranian attacks on shipping](#). US–Iran talks have since resumed, though these were reportedly [focused on the Strait of Hormuz and the release of Iran’s frozen assets abroad](#), rather than wider issues.

Both sides have warned of further military action. On 28 June, [President Trump echoed an earlier statement from April](#) and said that [the US may “be forced to militarily complete the job”](#) and “if that happens, the Islamic Republic of Iran will no longer exist!”.

On 30 June, Iran’s acting Defence Minister, Brigadier General Majid Ibn Rezahas, said that [“the other side has violated its commitments on several occasions”](#) and that “if any provision of the ceasefire is violated, we will take the necessary and proportionate action and will respond accordingly”.

1.3

Memorandum of understanding, June 2026

On 18 June 2026, Pakistan’s Prime Minister, Shehbaz Sharif, announced that the US and Iran had signed “the Islamabad Memorandum of Understanding” (MOU).¹³

The text has not been officially released by Pakistan, Iran or the US. The summary below is based on a readout to the media given by a US official and checked against an English-language version published by the Iranian President. There are only minor differences, found in paragraphs 1 and 3. The full text is provided at the end of this briefing (see the appendix).¹⁴

1: Ceasing hostilities “on all fronts”

The first paragraph says that the US and Iran, “and their allies” declare an “immediate and permanent termination of military operations on all fronts, including in Lebanon”. It also says that they will not “initiate any war or any military operation against each other” and that the final agreement will confirm the “permanent termination of the war on all fronts”.

As noted above, Iran has made the cessation of hostilities in Lebanon a condition for wider talks. Iran had cited Israeli military action against Hezbollah in its reasons for launching missile strikes against Israel on 7 June 2026, the first direct exchange of fire between the two since the April 2026 ceasefire was announced.¹⁵ Iran also cited Lebanon when announcing that it would close the Strait of Hormuz on 20 June 2026.¹⁶

The governments of Lebanon and Israel, and Iran-backed Hezbollah (a non-state group based in Lebanon and which the UK has proscribed as a terrorist organisation) did not participate in negotiations on the MOU. There are separate negotiations on ending that conflict; see section 2 of the Commons Library briefing [Israel–Hezbollah conflict 2026 and UK response](#).

2: Respect for sovereignty, territorial integrity and internal affairs

This is a short paragraph, emphasising non-interference by both sides.

Section 2.2 of this briefing and the Commons Library briefing [Israel–Hezbollah conflict 2026 and UK response](#) has more on the Israel–Hezbollah conflict.

¹³ Shehbaz Sharif on Twitter/X, “[I am honoured to announce that the historic ‘Islamabad Memorandum of Understanding’ has been electronically signed](#)”, 18 June 2026

¹⁴ Contents of the MOU are sourced from: CNN, “[US releases official agreement with Iran. Read the 14-point text](#)”, 17 June 2026; BBC News, [US–Iran memorandum of understanding in full](#), 17 June 2026; President Masoud Pezeshkian on Twitter/X, “[Memorandum of understanding between Iran and the US](#)”, 18 June 2026.

¹⁵ Tasmin News Agency, [Heavy strikes inflicted on key targets in Occupied Territories](#), 8 June 2026; New York Times, [Iran and Israel exchange strikes for first time since April ceasefire](#), 7 June 2026

¹⁶ BBC Monitoring, [Iran closes Strait of Hormuz over Israeli strikes in Lebanon](#), 20 June 2026

The US president does not consider the 60 days as a “hard deadline”.

3: Negotiating a final deal within 60 days

The MOU says Iran and the US intend to achieve a final deal within 60 days, though this period can be extended by mutual consent. The US President has said that he does not consider this a hard deadline, and that “it could take longer”.¹⁷

Many analysts have noted that it may be difficult to reach agreement within a 60-day period, citing the length of time required to reach the 2015 nuclear deal with Iran (see the Arms Control Association’s [Timeline of nuclear diplomacy with Iran, 1967-2023](#)), the failure to reach agreements in 2025 and earlier in 2026, and the requirement under paragraph 13 of the MOU (see below) to implement some of its paragraphs before other discussions can happen.¹⁸

4: Lifting the US blockade and removing its forces within 30 days

Section 2.3 has more on freedom of navigation in the Strait of Hormuz.

The MOU says that the process of lifting the US naval blockade on ships traversing to and from Iranian ports will begin “immediately” upon its signing and be completed within 30 days. The US said its blockade was lifted on 18 June, though it added that its naval ships would remain in the area.¹⁹

The US is also due to remove its forces from the “proximity of Iran” within 30 days. It is uncertain if this applies to US bases in the region.²⁰

5: Iran will facilitate commercial shipping traffic through Strait of Hormuz

Under the MOU, Iran is to “make arrangements using its best efforts for the safe passage of commercial vessels with no charge for 60 days only” through the Strait of Hormuz. It will also discuss the “future administration and maritime services” in the strait with other Gulf states, “in line with the applicable international law and the sovereign rights of coastal states”.

Iran has continued to negotiate with Oman on managing the strait, including the potential to impose fees or charges for transit (see section 2.3).

¹⁷ BBC News, [Trump: 60 days is not a hard deadline for a final agreement](#), 17 June 2026

¹⁸ The Hill, [Former Iran deal negotiator: 60 days is a ‘pretty short period of time’](#), 14 June 2026; International Crisis Group, [A creaky floor for US-Iran diplomacy](#), 14 June 2026; Time Magazine, [The 60-day test](#), 19 June 2026

¹⁹ US Central Command on Twitter/X, [“Today, US forces lifted the blockade \[...\]”](#), 18 June 2026

²⁰ Chatham House, [The US–Iran memorandum of understanding](#), 19 June 2026

6: Developing a US\$300 billion reconstruction plan for Iran

Section 2.4 has more on Iran's reconstruction.

Under the MOU, the US is to engage with regional states (namely, those in the Arab Gulf) to develop a reconstruction plan for Iran. The mechanism for implementing reconstruction will be agreed as part of the final deal. The US will waive any related sanctions to facilitate the investment.

7: The US and the UN will terminate sanctions on Iran

The US has imposed wide-ranging sanctions against Iran since 1979.

The US undertakes to terminate “all types of sanctions” against Iran under the MOU, including UN Security Council resolutions, resolutions of the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA; the organisation responsible for monitoring nuclear activity) and its own sanctions as part of an “agreed upon schedule as part of the final deal”.

For a summary of sanctions in place against Iran, see the US Congressional Research Service, [Iran sanctions](#) (February 2022). US sanctions originate from a range of sources, including the UN Security Council, US executive orders (made by the president) and the US Congress, and run back to the 1970s. For sanctions imposed by the UN Security Council, see section 1.3 of the Commons Library briefing [The E3 triggers snapback sanctions against Iran 2025](#) (September 2025). There are also [separate sanctions by countries including the UK](#), as well as the [European Union](#).²¹

Lifting sanctions will be related to Iran's nuclear programme (see paragraph 8). Lifting of sanctions made under UN Security Council resolutions will require all the permanent members (France, the UK, China, Russia and the US) not to veto the amending resolution.

8: Iran will not procure a nuclear weapon and allow inspections

Section 2.1 has more on Iran's nuclear programme.

Under the MOU, Iran “reaffirms” it will not develop or procure nuclear weapons. Iran and the US will also dispose of Iran's existing stockpile of highly enriched uranium. The IAEA will supervise the process.

9: Both sides will “maintain the status quo” until the final deal

Pending the final agreement, the MOU says that Iran will not make any changes to its nuclear programme, and the US will not deploy any further armed forces to the region (the area that this applies to is not detailed in the MOU) or apply new sanctions.

²¹ Reuters, [Undoing the 'tangled nest' of Iran sanctions won't be easy or quick](#), 23 June 2026

Almost all Iranian oil exports are to China.

The value of Iranian frozen assets likely runs into the tens of billions.

Section 2.4 has more on Iranian frozen funds.

Lebanon, Hormuz, releasing frozen assets and removing sanctions on oil are to be acted on first.

10: The US will lift sanctions on Iranian oil

Iranian oil exports, of which more than 90% go to China, constitute around a third of annual state revenue.²² Under the MOU, the US is to issue waivers for the export of Iranian crude oil, petroleum products and derivatives, as well as for associated services, such as banking.

The waiver was issued on 22 June 2026 and runs until 21 August 2026.²³ The US Treasury Secretary, Scott Bessent, said that it was a decision made in line with Iran’s commitment to reopening the Strait of Hormuz and permitting IAEA inspections (though this is disputed by Iran; see section 2.1).²⁴

11: The US will enable access to frozen funds

The MOU says that the US will make “fully available for use the frozen or restricted funds and assets” of Iran. On the MOU being implemented, Iran and the US will agree on the procedures for releasing these funds.

12: A monitoring mechanism will be established

The mechanism will monitor compliance with the MOU and the final deal.

13: Certain parts of the MOU must be met before others are discussed

Paragraph 13 says that negotiations on “the final deal” first depend on the “beginning of the implementation” of five paragraphs:

- paragraph 1: completely ceasing hostilities on all fronts
- paragraph 4: the US lifting its blockade and withdrawing its forces
- paragraph 5: Iran allowing ships through Hormuz
- paragraph 10: the US implementing the waiver on Iranian oil exports and related services
- paragraph 11: both sides agreeing a mechanism for releasing frozen Iranian assets

However, paragraph 8 (on Iran’s nuclear programme) also said the parties would “immediately address these [nuclear] issues”.

²² US-China Economic and Security Review Commission, [China-Iran factsheet](#), 16 March 2026; Commons Library briefing, [Iran: Introductory country profile](#), section 1

²³ US Treasury Department, [Issuance of Iran-related general licence](#), 22 June 2026

²⁴ Treasury Secretary Bessent on Twitter/X, “[Under President @realDonaldTrump \[...\]](#)”, 22 June 2026

On 30 June 2026, Iran’s Foreign Ministry said that “we have not yet entered the negotiation phase for the final agreement” because the other paragraphs had not yet been implemented.²⁵

14: The final deal will be endorsed in a UN Security Council resolution

Section 3 has more on UK, France, China and Russia responses in 2026

UN Security Council resolutions are binding. The 2015 nuclear agreement was also endorsed in a security council resolution ([2231 \(2015\)](#)).

As a security council resolution, it will be open to veto by the five permanent members (the UK, France, the US, China and Russia).

1.4

US and Iranian domestic actions on the MOU

There has been domestic opposition and debate on the MOU and its provisions in both the US and Iran.

US Congressional debate and oversight

The US Congress has oversight of any deal reached on Iran’s nuclear programme. Some Republicans are critical of the MOU.

In the US, Democrats and some Republican legislators have criticised the MOU. Criticisms relate to areas including sanctions relief, unfreezing Iranian assets and the halt on Israeli military action against Hezbollah in Lebanon.²⁶

The US Congress has oversight of agreements related to Iran’s nuclear program under the Iran Nuclear Agreement Review Act 2015. It will also be required to make changes to laws imposing sanctions on Iran.²⁷

Criticism by some Republicans of the MOU in 2026 follows the passage of resolutions in both the Senate and House of Representatives calling for the Trump administration either to halt the conflict with Iran or to seek congressional approval before continuing military action. A small number of Republicans, who hold majorities in both chambers, voted with the Democratic minority to pass the resolutions. President Trump rejected the Senate resolution, saying it was “poorly timed and meaningless”.²⁸

²⁵ Press TV, [Iran monitors US compliance moment-by-moment](#), 30 June 2026

²⁶ Senate Democrats, [Leader Schumer slams Trump’s Iran deal](#), 18 June 2026; The Hill, [Top Foreign Relations Democrat on Trump’s Iran deal](#), 18 June 2026; AP News, [Some GOP senators and Trump allies have harsh reviews of his agreement to end Iran war](#), 18 June 2026

²⁷ Congressional Research Service, [Possible US–Iran agreement: INARA and US sanctions](#), 17 June 2026

²⁸ PBS News, [What’s next for the war powers resolution on Iran? PolitiFact explains](#), 6 June 2026; AP, [Senate for first time approves a war powers resolution](#), 23 June 2026; Time Magazine, [Trump lashes out at ‘meaningless’ Senate rebuke over Iran war](#), 24 June 2026

Iranian Supreme Leader statement, parliamentary debate

Iran's Supreme Leader has authorised the MOU but says he had a "different view"

Iran's Supreme Leader, Mojtaba Khamenei, has said that "in principle", he holds a "different view" to the elected President of Iran on the MOU. However, he said that President Pezeshkian had "pledged [...] to safeguard the rights of the Iranian nation and the Resistance Front" (Iran-backed terrorist and armed groups like Hezbollah), and that as a result he had authorised the MOU signing.²⁹

There is an ongoing debate in Iran over whether the MOU requires the approval of Iran's parliament, with several "principalists" in the Iranian Parliament opposed to the agreement. These opponents have cited concessions on Iranian control over the Strait of Hormuz, on nuclear enrichment and on the Supreme Leader's statement (Iranian politics is broadly divided between "reformers" and "principalists"; for more, see the Commons Library briefing [Iran: Introductory country profile](#)).³⁰ Some members of the Assembly of Experts, the Iranian body responsible for appointing the Supreme Leader, have also warned against crossing Iran's "red lines" in the talks and the "harmful" nature of talks with the United States.³¹

Some leading parliamentarians and clerics warn Iran's "red lines" might be crossed in talks with the US.

Under article 77 of Iran's constitution, "international treaties, protocols, contracts, and agreements must be approved" by its parliament.³² However, the status of the 2026 MOU remains unresolved.³³ In the event of continued dispute, the Iranian constitution says that the 12-strong Guardian Council, whose members were aligned with and appointed by the former Supreme Leader, Ali Khamenei (father of Mojtaba), will make a ruling.³⁴

The 2015 nuclear deal was not formally endorsed by the Iranian Parliament. Instead, a separate bill was passed.³⁵

Further reading on the June 2026 MOU

- Foreign Policy, [Is the MOU a treaty or not? And why should we care?](#), 23 June 2026

²⁹ BBC Monitoring, [Iran's Khamenei endorses deal with US](#), 18 June 2026

³⁰ BBC Monitoring, [Why is Iran-US deal facing a hardline backlash in Tehran?](#), 16 June 2026

³¹ BBC Monitoring, [Iran's clerical body signals infighting over US talks](#), 28 June 2026

³² [Iranian Constitution](#), as amended to 1989, section 77

³³ BBC Monitoring, [Does Tehran-Washington MoU require Iran's parliamentary approval?](#), 25 June 2026

³⁴ Commons Library, [Iran: Introductory country profile](#), pp6, 11

³⁵ Wall Street Journal, [Iran leaders say parliament will have final say on fate of nuclear deal](#), 3 September 2015

- BBC News, [Weapons, money and ships: How is this Iran deal different from others?](#), 18 June 2026
- Foreign Affairs, [When a cease-fire is really a stalemate](#), 19 June 2026
- ACAPS, [US-Israel-Iran: Four scenarios for the regional conflict: June-December 2026 outlook](#) (PDF), 22 June 2026
- Chatham House, [The US–Iran memorandum of understanding nods to international law](#), 19 June 2026
- Chatham House, [Can the deal between US and Iran become a lasting settlement?](#), 15 June 2026
- Italian Institute for International Political Studies, [The US-Iran memorandum and the road ahead](#), 18 June 2026
- Royal United Services Institute, [The peace that was not one: The US-Iran memorandum risks permanent crisis](#), 19 June 2026

2

Topics in the 2026 US–Iran talks

There are four major issues being discussed in the 2026 US–Iran talks, many of which echo those discussed in previous rounds of talks (most notably, in the lead up to the 2015 nuclear deal).³⁶ The major issues are:

- Iran’s nuclear and ballistic missile programme
- Iran’s support for armed and terrorist groups abroad
- freedom of navigation in the Strait of Hormuz
- US sanctions relief and reconstruction

Hormuz is an issue new to talks in 2026, with Iran not claiming control of the strait before the 2026 conflict. These four issues are described below.

2.1

Iran’s nuclear and ballistic missile programme

When the US announced the start of strikes against Iran in 2026, President Trump cited as reasons for the strikes the failure to reach an agreement with Iran to curtail its nuclear programme and Iran’s continued development of ballistic missiles.

In 2025 and 2026 talks, the US position has been that Iran must no longer enrich any uranium. Iran has long said that its nuclear programme is peaceful and that it has a right to enrich uranium. In June 2025, the IAEA had said Iran was in breach of its non-proliferation obligations.³⁷

³⁶ Radio Free Liberty Europe, [The key sticking points to a US-Iran deal aimed at averting war](#), 4 February 2026; US State Department, [Secretary of State Marco Rubio remarks to press](#), 25 February 2026; Reuters, [Tehran is ready for nuclear concessions if US meets demands, Iranian official says](#), 22 February 2022

³⁷ See section 1.1 of the Commons Library briefing on the [Israel/US-Iran conflict 2026: Background and UK response](#)

The US says it has destroyed Iran's nuclear programme. It wants Iran to commit to stop pursuing a nuclear weapon. Iran has said its programme is peaceful.

Iran and the US disagree on whether Iran can enrich any uranium.

Iran not procuring a nuclear weapon is a “core” US aim

Speaking on 12 April 2026, Vice President JD Vance said that the US's “core goal” is for Iran to affirm that it will not aim to build a nuclear weapon:

The simple fact is that we need to see affirmative commitment that they will not seek a nuclear weapon, and they will not seek the tools that would enable them to quickly achieve a nuclear weapon.³⁸

In addition to nuclear enrichment, this may also include related missile and weapon technology. Restrictions on some of these were part of existing UN Security Council resolutions on Iran that were lifted under [the 2015 nuclear deal](#), before being [reimposed by the UK and others in September 2025](#).

On 27 June 2026, the US Vice President also said that while a “final deal” with Iran would be “great”, Iran's “nuclear program is still destroyed”, regardless of whether a new deal is achieved.³⁹ As set out in section 1.1 of the Commons Library briefing on the [Israel/US–Iran conflict 2026: Background and UK response](#), IAEA inspectors have been unable to verify the extent of damage to Iran's nuclear facilities following the US/Israeli strikes in 2025 and 2026.

The US wants zero enrichment by Iran

The US position in 2025 and 2026 has been that Iran must conduct “zero enrichment”.⁴⁰ This was rejected by Iran on several occasions.⁴¹

Following the April 2026 announcement of talks between the US and Iran, on 8 April President Trump said that Iran had agreed to stop enriching uranium.⁴² However, the head of Iran's Atomic Energy Organization has said Iran will not accept limits on its nuclear enrichment, and in May the Foreign Affairs Ministry said that nuclear enrichment is a right that “already exists”.⁴³

In June, President Trump said that a 20-year ban on Iranian enrichment “is enough”, if guarantees were sufficient (during April 2026 talks, Iran reportedly countered with five years).⁴⁴

³⁸ White House on Twitter/X, “[Vice President JD Vance gives an update in Pakistan](#)”, 12 April 2026

³⁹ The Hill, [Vance defends Iran strategy amid peace negotiations: ‘America wins either way’](#), 27 June 2026

⁴⁰ Reuters, [Trump envoy Witkoff cites US ‘red line’](#), 18 May 2026

⁴¹ Foreign Minister Araghchi on Twitter/X, “[Set to travel to Rome for 5th round](#)”, 22 May 2025; BBC Monitoring, [Why does Iran want to enrich uranium?](#), 3 July 2025

⁴² President Trump on Truth Social, “[The United States will work closely with Iran](#)”, 8 April 2026

⁴³ Asharq Al-Awsat, [Iran rejects curbs on its uranium enrichment program](#), 9 April 2026; Al Jazeera, [Iran says nuclear enrichment rights cannot be ‘negotiated’](#), 18 May 2026

⁴⁴ Times of Israel, [Trump says he’s OK with Iran suspending nuke enrichment for 20 years](#), 15 May 2026; Axios News, [US asked Iran to freeze uranium enrichment for 20 years, sources say](#), 13 April 2026; New York Times, [Iran proposes suspending nuclear activity for five years](#), 13 April 2026

Under the June MOU, talks will be held on “Iran’s nuclear needs”. It does not provide further detail on this, though media reports in April 2026 suggested potential US support for Iran’s civilian nuclear industry (see page 6).

Iran has an existing civilian programme.

Since the late 1960s, Iran has had a civilian nuclear programme (though its establishment has been subject to significant delays and interruption).⁴⁵ In 2025, Iran had signed a strategic partnership agreement with Russia, in which it said civilian reactors would be developed.⁴⁶ In 2011, Russian assistance had been provided to construct a civilian reactor in Iran.⁴⁷

Proposal to send enriched uranium abroad

Negotiations on the nuclear issue have periodically raised proposals for another country, such as Russia, to take Iran’s enriched uranium (see Russia’s statement in 2026, in section 3.4).⁴⁸ However, on 17 April, the Iranian Foreign Ministry said that uranium “will under no circumstances be transferred anywhere”.⁴⁹

Iran says the level of enrichment is negotiable

Iran has enriched uranium beyond the levels needed for civilian purposes.

While Iran says its nuclear programme is for civilian purposes only, it has enriched uranium beyond levels needed for civilian uses. In April 2026, the Iranian Government had said while it must retain the right to enrich uranium, the amount and level of enrichment was “negotiable”.⁵⁰

Under the [2015 nuclear deal](#), Iran had agreed to enrich uranium to a maximum purity of 3.67%, and to [cap its stockpile of enriched uranium above this at 300 kg](#) (PDF), down from 10,000 kg, for a 15-year period.

In early June 2025, the International Atomic Energy Association said it had verified Iran had more than 400 kg of uranium enriched to 60%. Weapons-grade uranium is enriched to 90%, and civilian uses require 3.67%.⁵¹ Sections 2 to 4 of the Commons Library briefing [Israel-Iran 2025: Developments in Iran’s nuclear programme and military action](#) provide an overview of the topic.

⁴⁵ Arms Control Association, [Timeline of nuclear diplomacy with Iran, 1967-2023](#), 2023; IAEA, [Country nuclear power profile: Iran](#)

⁴⁶ Iranian President, [Iran-Russia comprehensive strategic partnership treaty 2025](#), article 23

⁴⁷ Stimson, [Will a nuclear deal affect Iran-Russia civilian nuclear cooperation?](#), 5 June 2025

⁴⁸ Reuters, [Russia says it's ready to remove highly enriched uranium from Iran](#), 11 June 2025

⁴⁹ BBC News, [“Iran's uranium will not be transferred anywhere, says spokesman”](#), 17 April 2026

⁵⁰ Al-Arabiya, [Iran foreign ministry insists on right to enrich uranium, says level negotiable](#), 15 April 2026

⁵¹ IAEA, [Update on Developments in Iran \(6\)](#), 24 June 2026

Nuclear inspections may resume under the deal

Article 8 of the MOU says that, subject to the final agreement, the IAEA will supervise the disposal of Iran’s enriched uranium. The agency, which is responsible for monitoring Iran’s nuclear programme, has been unable to verify any damage and the extent of Iran’s nuclear programme since the June 2025 Israel/US strikes.⁵²

However, there is disagreement between the US and Iran on whether the inspection of Iranian nuclear sites and enriched material has been agreed.

The IAEA has “lost continuity of knowledge” on some of Iran’s nuclear material.

IAEA inspections have been limited in recent years, and in November 2025 the agency said that it had “lost continuity of knowledge in relation to the previously declared inventories of nuclear material in Iran” at several sites, including those attacked by the US and Israel in June 2025.⁵³

Shortly before the signing of the MOU, on 15 June 2026, Vice President Vance said that a “core part” of the agreement was “that the [International Atomic Energy Agency] and the United States are going to help Iran destroy the highly enriched stockpile” of uranium.⁵⁴ On 23 June, President Trump also said that “Iran has fully and completely agreed to highest level nuclear inspections long into the future (Infinity!!!)”. He said if Iran did not, there would be “no further negotiations”.⁵⁵

Iran has said it has not committed to this, and on 23 June an Iranian Foreign Ministry spokesperson said that the country would not discuss nuclear issues until other issues, such as the Israel–Hezbollah ceasefire, were resolved.⁵⁶

Iran and the US disagree on whether inspections have been agreed.

Despite these public disagreements, on 24 June the IAEA director general, Rafael Grossi, said that he expected inspections to happen and that the agency would be “working on the modalities - dates, procedures, places - very soon”. He said that the “fundamental thing” is that the MOU “says explicitly that the nuclear activities that are going to be carried out [...] supervised by the IAEA”.⁵⁷

⁵² AP, [UN nuclear watchdog says it’s unable to verify whether Iran has suspended all uranium enrichment](#), 27 February 2026

⁵³ IAEA, [NPT Safeguards Agreement with the Islamic Republic of Iran](#) (PDF), 2025, para 33

⁵⁴ BBC News, [Trump may release US–Iran deal before Friday, Vance says](#), 15 June 2026

⁵⁵ President Trump on Truth Social, [“Despite their protestations and false statements \[...\]”](#), 23 June 2026

⁵⁶ BBC News, [Iran says no new commitments on nuclear sites](#), 23 June 2026

⁵⁷ Reuters, [IAEA chief says Iran inspections will go ahead](#), 24 June 2026; UN News, [US–Iran deal: technical work can begin, says atomic energy agency](#), 18 June 2026; BBC News, [UN nuclear chief says inspectors will visit Iran sites](#), 24 June 2026

The US President says this is not an urgent priority.

Recovery of Iran’s enriched material

Following the [2025 US/Israeli strikes on Iran’s nuclear sites](#), some nuclear material remains at the targeted sites across Iran. In May and June 2026, President Trump had suggested that the US would recover this material “in the not-too-distant future”, and that this could happen without a deal with Iran.⁵⁸

On 5 and 16 June, he said that there was no urgency to recover it, as it is “entombed”, with his focus instead being on Iran never holding a nuclear weapon.⁵⁹

Ballistic missile programme

The US President says Iran can keep some ballistic missiles. Iran says they are not for negotiation.

A further US aim has been to curtail Iran’s ballistic missile programme, which could potentially lead to the development of a missile capable of carrying a nuclear warhead. This was a stated aim of the 2026 attacks (to “destroy their missiles and raise their missile industry to the ground”) and the February 2025 announcement to expand US sanctions against Iran.⁶⁰

It was also a point on which in 2020 the Commons Foreign Affairs Committee criticised the 2015 nuclear agreement, in that it did not “prohibit Iran from developing ballistic missiles capable of delivering nuclear warheads”. The committee recommended that a future deal should include “binding” commitments.⁶¹

However, on 12 June 2026 the US President said that Iran should be allowed to maintain ballistic missiles, in “relative proportion” to neighbouring Arab Gulf states, as “if other countries have them, it’s a little bit unfair for them not to have some”.⁶²

In 2025 and 2026, the Iranian Government had said its missiles, as well as its drones, were “not up for negotiation”.⁶³

⁵⁸ Times of Israel, [‘It’s entombed’: Trump says US can retrieve Iran’s uranium without a deal](#), 5 June 2026

⁵⁹ As above and BBC News, [No rush on confiscating enriched uranium – Trump](#), 16 June 2026

⁶⁰ President Trump on Truth Social, [Video of 28 February 2026](#); White House, [Fact sheet: President Donald J. Trump restores maximum pressure on Iran](#), 4 February 2025

⁶¹ Commons Foreign Affairs Committee, [No prosperity without justice: the UK’s relationship with Iran](#), 2020, para 19

⁶² Times of Israel, [As deal takes force, Trump says ‘it’s okay’ for Iran to have some ballistic missiles](#), 18 June 2026

⁶³ Tehran Times, [We won’t negotiate our missiles: Iran foreign ministry](#), 9 September 2025; Financial Times, [Iran says it will not negotiate with US on ballistic missiles](#), 30 January 2026; Saudi Gazette, [Iran says its missile program not part of future negotiations](#), 18 June 2026; BBC Monitoring, [Iran’s acting defence minister says missile, drone programmes ‘non-negotiable’](#), 1 July 2026

Iran has an extensive and developed ballistic missile programme. For a summary, see section 1.1 of the Commons Library briefing [Israel/US-Iran conflict 2026: Background and UK response](#).

Further reading on the MOU and nuclear programme

- Foreign Policy, [What Is Iran’s nuclear status quo?](#), 24 June 2026
- Financial Times, [How to bridge the impasse over Iran's nuclear programme](#), 22 June 2026
- Royal United Services Institute, [The nuclear question](#), 18 June 2026
- Arab Center Washington DC, [Iran’s nuclear leverage survives the war](#), 24 June 2026
- Foreign Policy, [Preventing an Iranian nuclear bomb is only getting harder](#), 7 April 2026

2.2

Iran’s support for armed and terrorist groups

Ending the Israel–Hezbollah conflict is an Iranian condition for talks on other aspects of the MOU

Paragraph 1 of the MOU says that, on behalf of their allies (referring to Israel and Hezbollah), the US and Iran agree to cease fighting on all fronts in 2026, including in Lebanon. However, there are separate negotiations ongoing around the Israel–Hezbollah conflict. These are set out in section 2 of the Commons Library briefing [Israel–Hezbollah conflict 2026 and UK response](#).

On 18 June 2026, after the MOU was signed, President Trump said that “we expect a complete ceasefire on all fronts, including Lebanon, Hezbollah, and Israel”. Iran has said that fighting between Israel and Hezbollah would violate the MOU.⁶⁴

⁶⁴ President Trump on Truth Social, “[The United States is committed to PEACE](#)”, 18 June 2026; Islamic Republic News Agency, [Israeli attack, continued occupation of Lebanon will breach Iran-US MoU: Araghchi](#), 16 June 2026

The US says the MOU commits Iran to stop funding terrorist groups.

Iran has said it will continue to support Hezbollah and groups.

One of President Trump’s aims in expanding sanctions against Iran in 2025 was to “neutrali[se]” “Iran’s terrorist network”, and in April 2026 he said that Iran “must” stop funding Hezbollah in Lebanon if a deal is to be reached.⁶⁵

After the MOU was signed in June 2026, the president had also said that “Iran must immediately stop their highly paid proxies in Lebanon [Hezbollah] from causing trouble. If they don’t, we’ll hit Iran very hard again”.⁶⁶

Vice President JD Vance has said that under the first paragraph of the MOU, Iran has committed to regional peace, and so will “stop funding violent terrorist organizations”.⁶⁷

Iran has long supported such groups, including Hamas in Gaza. In May 2026, it said its support will continue.⁶⁸

The 2015 nuclear agreement did not restrict Iran’s support for these groups (beyond existing sanctions). This led to criticism from the Arab Gulf states, for whom it was a key demand, as well as the Commons Foreign Affairs Committee in 2020, which said there was a need to secure regional security.⁶⁹

Hamas and Hezbollah have not agreed to disarm

Separate negotiations in 2026 have addressed Iran’s support for armed groups. The October 2025 framework between Israel and Hamas includes a provision for Hamas to disarm, while Lebanon–Israel negotiations in 2026 include the prospect of Hezbollah’s disarmament, which has long been an aim of Israel and the Lebanese Armed Forces. In 2026, the new Iraqi Government has also committed to absorbing the Popular Mobilisation Forces, some of which are backed by Iran, into the Iraqi Armed Forces.

To date, both Hamas and Hezbollah have rejected disarmament proposals, citing threats from Israel. See section 4 of the Commons Library briefing [Gaza 2026: Board of Peace and National Transitional Committee](#). For more on Lebanon, see [Lebanon 2025: Plans to disarm Hezbollah](#) and section 2 of [2026 Israel-Hezbollah conflict](#).

Iraq’s negotiations are ongoing, with a deadline of September 2026. See the Commons Library briefing [A new president and prime minister for Iraq](#) and

⁶⁵ White House, [Fact Sheet: President Donald J. Trump Restores Maximum Pressure on Iran](#), 4 February 2025; Times of Israel, [Trump declares 3-week truce extension](#), 24 April 2026

⁶⁶ President Trump on Truth Social, “[Iran must immediately stop \[...\]](#)”, 21 June 2026

⁶⁷ CNN, [The lead with Jake Tapper: Vice President JD Vance](#), 15 June 2026

⁶⁸ WANA Iran, [Iran will not abandon support for Hezbollah](#), 23 May 2026; Jerusalem Post, [Islamic regime ‘will not abandon’ Hezbollah. Araghchi promises in message to Qassem](#), 24 May 2026

⁶⁹ Al Monitor, [Gulf states want Iran deal talks to address Tehran’s missiles program, support for proxy groups](#), 16 June 2021; Commons Foreign Affairs Committee, [No prosperity without justice: the UK’s relationship with Iran](#), 2020, paras 9, 35

BBC Monitoring, [Iraq sets September deadline for weapons outside state control](#) (29 June 2026).

Iran is seeking “firm” guarantees against further attacks.

Iran says it wants a regional security agreement

In June 2026, Iran also signalled that it wanted “security agreements that would be sustained through economic cooperation” with Arab Gulf states. These would be based on “mutual respect and non-interference”.⁷⁰ This followed a statement in March 2026 by the Iranian President, who said there should be “firm [international] guarantees against future aggression”, and said this was the “only way to end this war” (alongside recognising “Iran’s legitimate rights” and payment of reparations (see section 2.4)).⁷¹

In April 2026, Iran’s ambassador to China had also suggested international guarantees against future conflict could include powers like China, Pakistan, Turkey and Russia.⁷²

For the views of Arab Gulf states regarding the conflict and the MOU, see section 3.3.

2.3

Freedom of navigation in the Strait of Hormuz

Reestablishing freedom of navigation in the Strait of Hormuz is on the UK ‘s [and international priorities in 2026](#). However, before the conflict began in February 2026, Iran did not claim control over the strait, which it managed jointly, with no tolls or fees, with Oman. This changed during the 2026 conflict, with Iran aiming to use the economic leverage provided by its control of the strait to deter further attacks.

Section 1.2 of the [Commons Library briefing on the Strait of Hormuz](#) has more on the strait and developments in 2026.

Both Iran and the US said they would lift their blockades in June

Following the April 2026 announcement, President Trump said that the pause on US strikes was subject to the “complete, immediate, and safe opening of the Strait of Hormuz”, while Iran had described the US counter-blockade (targeting ships trying to access Iranian ports from 13 April) as a potential “prelude to a violation of the ceasefire”.⁷³

⁷⁰ BBC Monitoring, [Qalibaf says Iran ready for security agreements with Gulf states](#), 24 June 2026

⁷¹ AA, [Iranian president says recognizing Iran’s ‘legitimate rights’](#), 11 March 2026

⁷² BBC Monitoring, [Beijing quiet on Iran war truce involvement, security guarantees](#), 8 April 2026

⁷³ President Trump on Truth Social, [“Based on conversations with Prime Minister Shabbaz Sharif”](#), 7 April 2026; Al Jazeera, [Iran warns US naval blockade threatens ceasefire](#), 15 April 2026

Iran says all ships must coordinate their travel with Iranian authorities.

Both said they would remove their blockades after the signing of the June 2026 MOU. On 23 June 2026, President Trump said that “all [US] ships are remaining in place, should it be necessary to reinstitute the [US] blockade”.⁷⁴

Iran has said that ships passing through the Strait of Hormuz during the MOU period must do so in coordination with Iranian authorities.⁷⁵ On 19 June, the maritime monitoring organisation Lloyd’s List said that Iran had introduced mandatory, but free, insurance for ships traversing the strait for 60 days.⁷⁶

On 20 June, the US Central Command reported that commercial ship traffic had begun to increase through the strait, but, as World Trade Organization data shows, shipping numbers since have remained very low.⁷⁷

As noted above, Iran said it would shut the strait in response to the continuing conflict in Lebanon, and did so on 20 June 2026.⁷⁸ Iran also struck a ship traversing the strait on 25 June, warning against any ship movement outside the Iran-designated route through the strait. This resulted in a further round of armed conflict between Iran and the US (see above, page 7).⁷⁹

A humanitarian corridor organised by the International Maritime Organization and Oman to support ships stranded since February to exit the strait was also suspended after Iran–US strikes from 25 June.⁸⁰

Iran is holding talks with Oman on the Strait

Speaking on 25 March, Iran’s Foreign Minister, Abbas Araqchi, said “we intend to devise a new arrangement to ensure secure maritime traffic through the waterway” after the conflict.⁸¹

Iranian negotiations have said fees will be collected.

Iranian officials have continued to assert their right to control the passageway. On 17 June, one of Iran’s negotiators in the Pakistan-mediated talks, Parliament Speaker Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf, said that “Iran has the right to sovereignty over the Strait of Hormuz and of course we will receive a fee for services”.⁸²

Oman opposes tolls to access the strait.

Under the June MOU, Iran is to discuss the future “administration and maritime services” of Hormuz with other Gulf States, in line with “applicable international law and the sovereign rights of coastal states” (for international

⁷⁴ President Trump on Truth Social, “[Despite their protestations and false statements](#)”, 23 June 2026

⁷⁵ BBC News, [Iran’s security council says ships must apply to use Strait of Hormuz](#), 18 June 2026

⁷⁶ Lloyd’s List, [Iran imposes mandatory insurance](#), 19 June 2026

⁷⁷ Centcom, [Commercial vessels flow](#), 20 June 2026; World Trade Organization, [Strait of Hormuz trade tracker](#), updated 29 June 2026

⁷⁸ BBC Monitoring, [Iran closes Strait of Hormuz over Israeli strikes in Lebanon](#), 20 June 2026

⁷⁹ New York Times, [Iran strikes ship in Strait of Hormuz](#), 25 June 2026

⁸⁰ The National, [Oman and UN set up corridor for safe passage of ships](#), 24 June 2026; UN, [Strait of Hormuz: UN evacuates 2,500 seafarers](#), 26 June 2026

⁸¹ BBC Monitoring, [Iran says its control over Strait of Hormuz will continue](#), 25 March 2026

⁸² BBC News, [Iran to charge ships crossing Strait of Hormuz](#), 17 June 2026

law and tolls, see pages 9 to 11 of the Commons Library briefing on [Reopening the Strait of Hormuz](#)).

In its talks with Iran, Oman, the other state with a coastline on the strait, has reiterated its support for toll-free access through it.⁸³ An Oman–Iran statement on their negotiations, which was published in June, confirms that one issue under negotiation is “the services that will be provided” on navigation through Hormuz “and the costs associated with them in accordance with international standards”.⁸⁴

The US opposes any tolls

The US says tolls cannot form part of any deal with Iran.

On 20 June, the US President reiterated his opposition to any tolls in the strait. He said that there would be no tolls during the 60-day MOU-negotiated period, or after.⁸⁵ The US Secretary of State, Marco Rubio, has also said that any tolls or fees “will never be an acceptable condition of any deal”.⁸⁶

2.4

US sanctions and reconstruction

There are extensive US and international sanctions against Iran, and their removal has been one of Iran’s central aims. In part, this reflects its deteriorating economy. The MOU sets out plans for a US\$300 billion reconstruction fund for Iran and lifting of restrictions on Iranian assets frozen abroad.

Iran’s economy has been struggling under sanctions

Since 1979, Iran has become one of the world’s most sanctioned countries. Trade restrictions have included US sanctions on Iran’s oil exports. Since the US withdrew from the 2015 nuclear deal in 2018 and reimposed extensive sanctions, [Iran has experienced high rates of inflation](#). Section 1 of the [Commons Library’s introduction to Iran](#) has more information on Iran’s economy.

A March 2026 report by the UN Development Programme projects that these challenges to Iran’s economy will continue. A sustained fall in traffic through Hormuz, through which many Iranian imports and exports flow, will further

⁸³ BBC Monitoring, [Oman rejects Hormuz transit fees](#), 25 June 2026

⁸⁴ Oman Foreign Ministry on Twitter/X, “[Joint statement by the Sultanate of Oman and the Islamic Republic of Iran](#)”, 23 June 2026

⁸⁵ President Trump on Truth Social “[There will be no tolls in the Hormuz Strait for 60 days](#)”, 20 June 2026

⁸⁶ US State Department, [Secretary of State Marco Rubio and Bahraini Foreign Minister Abdullatif bin Rashid Al Zayani](#), 25 June 2026

exacerbate this.⁸⁷ In June 2026, Iranian officials had recorded a year-on-year inflation rate of 84%, while inflation in some food essentials rose even higher: bread and cereals inflation rose to 114% and oils and fats rose to 121%.⁸⁸

The damage from the US/Israel strikes in 2026 is extensive. In April 2026, one Iranian official suggested there had been US\$270 billion of direct and indirect damage caused within Iran, and said that the issue of compensation, including from Gulf states, had been raised with mediators.⁸⁹

In April, Iran had called for reparations.

The Iranian President, Masoud Pezeshkian, also suggested in March 2026 that the payment of reparations was the “only way” to end the conflict.⁹⁰ Iran also wants the US to release the frozen state funds and assets that it holds.⁹¹

The value of Iranian assets frozen abroad is uncertain, but estimates run into the tens of billions.⁹²

In early June, the US had suggested Iranian assets could be given to Gulf states.

The US Treasury Secretary, Scott Bessent, had previously said in early June 2026 that “any damage [Iran] inflicts on our allies in the Gulf will be paid for with funds extracted from Iranian accounts”. This provision was not included in the June MOU.⁹³

US statements on the reconstruction fund for Iran

In April 2026, President Trump said that with the conditional ceasefire “Iran can start the reconstruction process” and “big money will be made”, though Vice President Vance said Iran must “act like a normal country” before the US “treat[s] you economically like a normal country”.⁹⁴

The US says it will not be funding Iranian reconstruction.

President Trump has said that no US funds will form part of the US\$300 billion reconstruction fund for Iran under paragraph 6 of the MOU.⁹⁵ Reuters news agency has reported that the fund will be a “private investment vehicle” and “will not include any government money or grants”. However, no public statements have been made to confirm this or who will participate.⁹⁶

⁸⁷ UN Development Programme, [Military escalation threatens human and economic development gains across Iran](#), 31 March 2026

⁸⁸ BBC Monitoring, [Iran year-on-year inflation hits 83.9%](#), 2 June 2026

⁸⁹ Al Jazeera, [Iran says \\$270bn war loss must be compensated, as fresh talks with US loom](#), 15 April 2026; The National, [Iran demands compensation from Gulf states](#), 14 April 2026

⁹⁰ AA, [Iranian president says recognizing Iran's 'legitimate rights'](#), 11 March 2026

⁹¹ BBC News, [The 10-point plan for the conditional ceasefire, according to Iran](#), 7 April 2026

⁹² The Conversation, [Iran's frozen funds: how much is really there and how will they be used?](#), 11 August 2015; Wall Street Journal, [See where Iran's billions of dollars in frozen assets are held](#), 16 June 2026;

⁹³ Al Monitor, [Bessent says Iran's frozen assets will pay for Gulf damage, Hormuz tolls](#), 11 June 2026

⁹⁴ President Trump on Truth Social, “[A big day for World Peace!](#)”, 8 April 2026; Wall Street Journal, [Iran can thrive if it commits to not having nuclear weapon, Vance Says](#), 14 April 2026

⁹⁵ The Hill, [Trump: 'We are not investing any money in Iran'](#), 16 June 2026

⁹⁶ Reuters, [Iran deal includes \\$300 billion fund](#), 17 June 2026

Release of Iranian assets

In mid-June 2026, the Washington Post had reported that the first funds released may be around US\$6 billion of assets held in Qatar, with the funding to be restricted to food, medicine and other humanitarian goods.⁹⁷ Reuters has also suggested the UAE had, or could, make funds available (having been [one of the most critical Gulf states during the conflict](#)), though its government said on 13 June that “no frozen Iranian funds have been released, transferred, or facilitated through the UAE”.⁹⁸

On 22 June, one of Iran’s negotiators, Parliament Speaker Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf, said that agreement on the release of US\$12 billion had been reached as part of the US\$300 billion reconstruction fund for Iran, though the US has not confirmed this agreement.⁹⁹

The US and Iran dispute what the released assets can be spent on.

President Trump has said that any released funds will be restricted to purchasing US food and medicine, but Iran’s Parliament Speaker, Foreign Ministry and head of the central bank have said there is “no obligation” to buy US agricultural products and “no restrictions” on what they can be used for.¹⁰⁰

The [Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps](#), which plays a leading role in Iran’s internal security and support for armed and terrorist groups abroad, and which also controls much of the Iranian economy, may gain from any sanctions relief or asset releases.¹⁰¹

⁹⁷ Wall Street, [US, Qatar work to give Iran access to billions of dollars in frozen cash](#), 19 June 2026

⁹⁸ Reuters, [UAE to unlock billions of dollars for Iran, sources say](#), 12 June 2026; Asharq Al-Awsat, [UAE Categorically denies reports alleging the transfer of funds to Iran](#), 13 June 2026

⁹⁹ The National, [Iran says agreement reached with US to release \\$12 billion in frozen funds](#), 23 June 2026

¹⁰⁰ President Trump on Truth Social, “[Despite their protestations and false statements \[...\]](#)”, 23 June 2026; Tasmin News Agency, [Qalibaf refutes US claims on Iran’s assets](#), 25 June 2026; BBC Monitoring, [Iran denies new nuclear concessions](#), 23 June 2026

¹⁰¹ Reuters, [Iranian Guards’ business empire to win big if US sanctions lifted](#), 22 June 2026

3 What have others called for in the talks?

Mediation between the US and Iran is being led by Pakistan. Israel, Lebanon, Arab Gulf countries and European states are not directly participating in the talks. Israel, which participated in the strikes against Iran alongside the US from February 2026, has reemphasised core priorities such as ending Iran's support for armed groups abroad and recovering Iran's enriched uranium.

3.1 UK and European states

The UK has welcomed the April and June 2026 agreements and said it is willing to lift sanctions against Iran if a new nuclear agreement is reached. It is also prepared to deploy a defensive mission to the Strait of Hormuz to secure freedom of navigation, but only when armed conflict subsides.

Support for the April and June 2026 agreements

On 9 April 2026, the UK and European Union welcomed the ceasefire announcement and called for a long-term agreement.¹⁰² In a statement signed by 39 other states, the UK also welcomed the June 2026 MOU. The signatories said that “detailed discussions” must be held on the MOU and the agreement “implemented rapidly and comprehensively”.¹⁰³

The UK, France and Germany have said they are open to lifting some sanctions if Iran takes certain steps.

In addition to calling for the reopening of Hormuz, calling for a ceasefire between Israel and Hezbollah in Lebanon, and stating that Iran must never acquire a nuclear weapon, the June 2026 signatories (including the UK, France and Germany) said that they were ready to lift “relevant sanctions” on Iran “in response to clear, verifiable steps by Iran on its nuclear programme”.¹⁰⁴

However, speaking in the same month, the EU's High Representative for Foreign Affairs, Kaja Kallas, said “we're not there yet” regarding talks on whether and how to lift sanctions on Iran.¹⁰⁵ France's Foreign Minister, Jean-Noël Barrot, said that France will not support the lifting of UN sanctions without a “radical change in Iran's stance”, which would include action on its ballistic missile programme and support for groups abroad.¹⁰⁶

¹⁰² European Council, [Statement by the high representative](#), 9 April 2026; HC Deb, [13 April 2026](#), c549

¹⁰³ Prime Minister's Office, [Joint E4 Leaders' Statement on the US-Iran peace deal](#), first published 14 June 2026

¹⁰⁴ Prime Minister's Office, [Joint E4 Leaders' Statement on the US-Iran peace deal](#), first published 14 June 2026; HC Deb, [13 April 2026](#), cc550, 561; Prime Minister's Office, [Joint E3 Leaders' Statement on Iran](#), 28 February 2026

¹⁰⁵ Reuters, [Not there yet on questions of lifting Iran sanctions, EU's Kallas says](#), 18 June 2026

¹⁰⁶ RFI, [No lifting of UN sanctions on Iran without France's approval, FM says](#), 19 June 2026

In 2025, the E3 triggered UN “snapback sanctions” under the 2015 nuclear deal.

In August 2025, the E3 (Germany, France and the UK) had triggered a mechanism in the 2015 Iran nuclear agreement to introduce ‘snapback sanctions’ against Iran. The British, French and German foreign ministers said that Iran was in a state of “significant non-performance” with its commitments under the agreement. Measures reimposed include a UN embargo on arms exports to Iran and restrictions on sensitive technology and goods linked to its nuclear programme.¹⁰⁷

In April 2026, the EU’s High Representative for Foreign Affairs had also said that there “must be nuclear experts around the table” during the US–Iran talks, otherwise “we will end up with an agreement that is weaker than the JCPOA [2015 Iran nuclear deal] was”. She also said that, working with regional partners, Iran’s “missile programmes, their support to proxies, [and] hybrid and cyber activities in Europe” needed to be addressed.¹⁰⁸

Measures on freedom of navigation through Hormuz

In June 2026, G7 governments (Canada, France, Germany, the UK, Italy, Japan and the US) also confirmed their support for the UK–France-led multinational mission to secure the strait for shipping (see section 1.4 of the [Commons Library briefing on the Strait of Hormuz](#)).¹⁰⁹

Further reading on the UK, Europe and Iran

- Commons Library, [Iranian state threat activities in the UK](#), June 2026
- Commons Library, [The E3 triggers snapback sanctions against Iran 2025](#), September 2025
- Intelligence and Security Committee of Parliament, [Iran](#), July 2025, and the [UK Government response](#), September 2025. The committee report includes chapters on Iran in the UK, Iran’s international partnerships, and its nuclear programme.
- European Council on Foreign Relations, [Making peace last: Steps for Europeans to support the Iran-US ceasefire](#), April 2026
- Policy Exchange, [Crisis and opportunity in the Middle East: UK Policy options towards Iran in 2025](#), January 2025
- Policy Exchange, [The Iran question and British strategy](#), July 2023

¹⁰⁷ Commons Library briefing, [The E3 triggers snapback sanctions against Iran 2025](#), September 2025. While Germany had the power to trigger snapback sanctions under the 2015 nuclear deal, as it is not a member of the UNSC it cannot veto any removal of sanctions under a new resolution.

¹⁰⁸ EU External Action, [Informal European Council: Press remarks](#), 24 April 2026

¹⁰⁹ Prime Minister’s Office, [G7 leaders’ statement on geopolitical issues](#), 17 June 2026

- Commons Foreign Affairs Committee, [No prosperity without justice: the UK's relationship with Iran](#), December 2020, and [UK Government response](#), February 2021

3.2

Israel expects action on Iran's nuclear and missile programmes and support for armed groups abroad.

Israel

Israel is not a party to the MOU, and several governing ministers and opposition figures have criticised the agreement. Israel's Prime Minister, Benjamin Netanyahu, says President Trump has told him that the final agreement with Iran will include several Israeli priorities, such as ending Iran's support for groups abroad.

Prime Minister Netanyahu's priorities

In response to publication of the Iran–US memorandum, on 11 June 2026, the Israeli Prime Minister, Benjamin Netanyahu, said “Israel is not a party to the memorandum of understanding”. He said that in his conversations with President Trump, the president had said the final agreement with Iran would include four elements:¹¹⁰

- the removal of enriched material (this was described by Israel's Foreign Minister as a [“precondition” for ending the conflict](#) in April)
- the dismantling of enrichment infrastructure
- limits on missile production
- the cessation of Iran's support for its terrorist proxies in the region

However, as noted in section 2, Iran largely opposes these measures.

These June press release echoes the four aims set out by the Israeli Prime Minister after the attacks began in February 2026, and his primary criticism against the 2015 nuclear deal with Iran, which restricted itself to limiting Iran's nuclear programme.¹¹¹ He had also included reopening Hormuz and “chang[ing] the face of the Middle East in Israel's favour” as Israeli aims in April.¹¹²

¹¹⁰ Israel Foreign Affairs Ministry, [PM Netanyahu speaks with President Trump](#), 11 June 2026

¹¹¹ PBS News, [Netanyahu's full statement on Iran attacks](#), 28 February 2026; Israel Foreign Affairs Ministry, [Statement by PM Netanyahu](#), 23 March 2026; US Institute for Peace, [Iran primer: Netanyahu speech: The text](#), 3 March 2015

¹¹² Israel Foreign Affairs Ministry, [Statement by PM Netanyahu](#), 8 April 2026

Israel says it will retain a presence in Lebanon as security against Hezbollah.

In a further statement of 15 June, the Israeli Prime Minister said that he would “not limit myself in any way” in ensuring Iran does not gain a nuclear weapon, and that he had been “very, very resolute” on Israel’s continued presence in Lebanon (see the separate Commons Library briefing on the [Israel-Hezbollah conflict in 2026](#)).¹¹³ On 24 June, Israel’s Defence Minister, Israel Katz, said that Israel would not withdraw from its “security zone” in southern Lebanon, “even if there is an American demand” (though he added that there had been no US demand).¹¹⁴

Increased Israel–US tensions in mid-2026

The US says Israel “must respect” talks with Iran in 2026.

The US–Iran MOU comes at a time of increased tensions between the US and Israel. On 3 June, President Trump confirmed that he had described Mr Netanyahu as “crazy” because he was “a little bit perturbed at his constantly fighting with [Hezbollah in] Lebanon”.¹¹⁵ On 16 June, the president had also said that “Israel is fighting Hezbollah too long and too many people are being killed [...] and they’re not all Hezbollah”.¹¹⁶

Vice President Vance has echoed this criticism, saying the Israeli Government has “to respect this peace process” and that sometimes Israel and the US “have interests that are misaligned”.¹¹⁷

Further reading on Israel-US tensions in 2026

- Tel Aviv University Institute for National Security Studies, [The implications of the US-Iran memorandum of understanding](#), 22 June 2026
- Washington Institute, [Don’t mistake friction for a broken alliance with Israel](#), 16 June 2026
- Emirates Policy Center, [A strategic loss: Israel and the US-Iran MOU](#), 24 June 2026
- Foreign Policy, [The end of the US-Israel alliance](#), 15 June 2026
- Atlantic Council, [From a gap to a chasm: Diverging US and Israeli interests in the war with Iran](#), 10 June 2026

¹¹³ Times of Israel, [Netanyahu says details of US-Iran deal aren’t yet known](#), 15 June 2026

¹¹⁴ Times of Israel, [Katz vows no IDF withdrawal from south Lebanon](#), 24 June 2026

¹¹⁵ Reuters, [Trump confirms he called Netanyahu crazy in phone call](#), 3 June 2026

¹¹⁶ Times of Israel, [Trump: Israel’s war on Hezbollah is too long, too deadly \[...\]](#), 16 June 2026

¹¹⁷ Times of Israel, [Vance: Israel must ‘respect this peace process’](#), 18 June 2026; CBS News, [Vance says Netanyahu has “certainly gotten some things wrong”](#), 10 June 2026

Israeli ministers and opposition leaders criticise the MOU

Parliamentary elections in Israel will be held by October 2026, and the nature of any agreement on Iran is likely to feature in the election campaign.

Several members of the ruling coalition government and opposition leaders were critical of the memorandum of understanding. The Finance Minister, Bezalel Smotrich, said the June MOU was “bad for Israel and for the entire free world” while the Security Minister, Itamar Ben Gvir, said that “Trump’s agreement does not bind us” and “we must not withdraw from any territory that our fighters have captured”. The opposition leader, Yair Lapid, said that the “Israel Defense Forces fulfilled its missions [but], Netanyahu failed to deliver the goods”.¹¹⁸

3.3

Arab Gulf states

The UAE, Bahrain, Saudi Arabia and Kuwait were the Gulf states most targeted by Iran.

The Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC; Bahrain, Kuwait, Oman, Saudi Arabia, Qatar and the UAE) welcomed the April and June agreements between the US and Iran. They have called for the final agreement to address Iran’s nuclear and ballistic missile programmes and its support for armed and terrorist groups in the region. The UAE and Bahrain have been the most critical of Iran in their public statements.

Gulf Cooperation Council statements

[Iran has attacked all neighbouring Arab Gulf states](#) with missiles and drones during the conflict, as it aimed to put economic and political pressure on its neighbours and their security ties with the US. The attacks followed a period of [rapprochement in Iran–Gulf state relations](#), but in 2026 several Gulf states expelled Iranian diplomats and officials. Bahrain never restored its relations with Iran after breaking them off in 2016.¹¹⁹

The GCC welcomed the ceasefire agreement in April 2026. In June 2026, the GCC said that further hostile attacks by Iran “do not serve any understanding or rapprochement” and said that “persistence in the path of aggression will only lead to further isolation”.¹²⁰ It also said that a wide range of Iranian actions were required for a “lasting regional peace”:

The ministers further emphasized that lasting regional peace and security requires addressing the full spectrum of Iran’s threats, including its ballistic

¹¹⁸ Times of Israel, [Ministers say Israel won’t be bound by Iran deal](#), 15 June 2026; Haaretz, [Ben-Gvir: ‘Trump’s agreement does not bind us’](#), 15 June 2026

¹¹⁹ Jerusalem Post, [Gulf states expel Iranian diplomats as tensions rise over attacks, regional security](#), 22 March 2026

¹²⁰ GCC, [Statement issued by the 167th Ministerial Council meeting of the GCC](#), 10 June 2026

missiles, drones, and its support of proxies in the region. The ministers also emphasised the importance of reopening the Strait of Hormuz, noting that free, unconditional, and unrestricted navigation, including the right of transit passage as guaranteed under international law, remains essential to regional and global security. The ministers rejected any tolls, fees, or attempts to assert control over the strait [...]¹²¹

UAE and Bahrain calls for restrictions on Iran

The United Arab Emirates and Bahrain have both called for a wide-ranging restrictions on Iran.

UAE statements

The United Arab Emirates (UAE) experienced the most Iranian attacks from February to April 2026, followed by Bahrain, Saudi Arabia and Kuwait.¹²²

The UAE has called for reparations and limits on Iran’s missile programme and support for armed groups.

The UAE has been the most publicly critical of Iran, with its ambassador to the US saying in March 2026 that “a simple cease-fire isn’t enough”.¹²³ The country has called for the “unconditional reopening of the Strait of Hormuz”, for Iran to held liable for reparations and damage, and for a wide agreement that curtails Iran’s support for armed groups in the region, as well as its ballistic and missile programme.¹²⁴

In June, the UAE also said that “any solution designed to deliver lasting security will be strongest when it reflects the perspectives of those whose security is most immediately affected”.¹²⁵

The UAE and Iranian foreign ministers spoke directly on 26 June. The UAE said there must be “full compliance with the provisions” of the MOU.¹²⁶

Bahrain statements

Bahrain has called for similar restrictions on Iran.

Bahrain has historic tensions with Iran, which it has accused of supporting opposition groups against its monarchy (for an overview, see pages 13 to 14 of the [Commons Library profile on Bahrain](#)).

In June 2026, Bahrain’s government said that several steps must be taken to achieve “lasting regional security”. This includes Iran including ending its support for armed and terrorist groups abroad and to cease interference in other states:

Alongside preventing Iran from acquiring a nuclear weapon and preserving freedom of navigation, lasting regional security requires a definitive end to

¹²¹ GCC, [Joint statement following the ministerial meeting of the US and the GCC](#), 25 June 2026

¹²² Institute for Study of War, [Iran update special report, April 8, 2026](#)

¹²³ Wall Street Journal, [The UAE stands up to Iran](#), 25 March 2026

¹²⁴ UAE Foreign Affairs Ministry, [UAE closely following ceasefire announcement](#), 8 April 2026

¹²⁵ UAE Foreign Affairs Ministry, [UAE stresses need for unity at GCC-US joint ministerial meeting](#), 26 June 2026

¹²⁶ UAE Foreign Affairs Ministry, [Abdullah bin Zayed receives phone call \[...\]](#), 26 June 2026

missile and drone attacks, ceasing support for militias, and halting interference in the sovereignty of our states. It is equally important to ensure that the consequences of those attacks are addressed consistent with United Nations Security Council Resolution 2817.¹²⁷

Saudi Arabia

Some analysts have argued that Saudi Arabia and the UAE are increasingly on opposite sides of two competing regional alignments, and that Saudi Arabia has adopted a more accommodating approach towards Iran in 2026 (alongside Pakistan, Turkey and Egypt).¹²⁸

Saudi Arabia has called for “all issues” that have contributed to instability to be addressed.

In June 2026, Pakistan’s Prime Minister thanked Saudi Arabia for its “indispensable role and invaluable contributions” in helping the MOU to be agreed.¹²⁹ Saudi Arabia’s Foreign Ministry welcomed the MOU and said that the agreement should take into account the security interests of regional countries and respect their internal affairs. It also said that access through the Strait of Hormuz should be restored to its pre-conflict state.¹³⁰

Saudi Arabia’s Foreign Affairs Minister has said that Saudi Arabia’s most important concern is verification of Iran’s uranium enrichment and removing nuclear material:

It will be most important to see the verification mechanisms that are (put) in place beyond the actual commitments on (uranium) enrichment, the actual commitment on the removal or downblending of nuclear materials.¹³¹

In April, Saudi Arabia had also said any deal should “address all issues” that have contributed to Middle East instability “over the past decades”.¹³²

Oman and Qatar have played a mediatory role

During the conflict, there were relatively fewer Iranian attacks on Qatar (though some attacks have caused major damage) and particularly Oman, both of which have historically helped mediate talks between Iran and other states.

Qatar is supporting the Pakistan-led mediation.

¹²⁷ US State Department, [Secretary of State Marco Rubio and Bahraini Foreign Minister Abdullatif bin Rashid Al Zayani](#), 25 June 2026. [UNSC 2817 was passed in 2026](#), condemning Iran’s drone and missile attacks on its neighbours

¹²⁸ See the Commons Library briefing, [The UAE exits OPEC and Saudi-UAE tensions in 2026](#)

¹²⁹ Pakistan Prime Minister Sharif on Twitter/X, “[I am honoured to announce \[...\]](#)”, 18 June 2026

¹³⁰ Saudi Arabia Foreign Ministry on Twitter/X, “[The Foreign Ministry expresses the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia’s welcome \[...\]](#)”, 15 June 2026

¹³¹ Reuters, [Verification is key in US-Iran nuclear talks, Saudi foreign minister says](#), 17 June 2026

¹³² Saudi Arabia Foreign Ministry on Twitter/X, “[The Foreign Ministry expresses the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia’s welcome \[...\]](#)”, 8 April 2026

Oman is in talks with Iran on the Strait of Hormuz.

Qatar has noted that “we will be neighbours [with Iran] for the future of humankind”, and that co-existence is needed.¹³³ As of June 2026, Qatar is supporting the negotiations with Pakistan.¹³⁴

Oman, the only Arab Gulf state to criticise the US and Israeli attacks directly, and to welcome the selection of the new Iranian Supreme Leader Mojtaba Khamenei, may aim to maintain a middle road between Iran, the US and the Arab Gulf. It has held some direct talks with Iran in 2026.¹³⁵ In its talks with Oman on the Strait of Hormuz (see above, section 2.3), it said in June that it has discussed topics of “mutual interest” and had “reaffirm[ed] their commitment to international law”.¹³⁶

Further reading on the Arab Gulf in 2026

- The Economist, [The Gulf's three post-war challenges](#), June 2026
- Congressional Research Service, [The Arab Gulf states, the Iran conflict, and US relations: In brief](#), June 2026
- Washington Institute, [A postwar Middle East? The US-Iran negotiations and the region's future](#), June 2026
- Arab Center Washington DC, [Limiting the damage: Saudi Arabia and the Islamabad Memorandum](#), June 2026
- Brookings Institute, [How the Iran war will change the Middle East](#), 10 June 2026
- Arab Center Washington DC, [Vision 2030 and the Iran War: Saudi Arabia's resilience under strain](#), May 2026
- Chatham House, [How the Iran war is reshaping Saudi strategy](#), May 2026
- Commons library, [The UAE exits OPEC and Saudi-UAE tensions in 2026](#), May 2026
- Middle East Council, [The Gulf Cooperation Council will not unify on Iran](#), 14 April 2026

¹³³ Al Jazeera Facebook, [Qatar's foreign affairs ministry spokesman](#), 24 March 2026

¹³⁴ Prime Minister Shebez Sharif, “[Following intensive talks, we are pleased to announce \[...\]](#)”, 14 June 2026; Qatar Foreign Affairs Ministry, [Joint Statement by the State of Qatar and the Islamic Republic of Pakistan](#), 22 June 2026

¹³⁵ BBC Monitoring, [How Oman is going against the Gulf grain on Iran](#), 1 April 2026; Oman Foreign Affairs Ministry, [Minister in phone call with Iranian counterpart](#), 25 June 2026

¹³⁶ Oman Foreign Affairs Ministry, [Oman-Iran committee on Strait of Hormuz](#), 29 June 2026

3.4

China and Russia

Iran’s ties with China and Russia have deepened in recent years (see section 7 of the [Commons Library profile on Iran](#)).

China welcomed the April and June agreements and had reportedly been encouraging Iran to seek a pause in the fighting in April.¹³⁷ Together with Pakistan, on 31 March China had published a five-point plan on the conflict. This included respecting “sovereignty, territorial integrity, national independence and security” of Iran and the Gulf, and “restor[ing] normal passage through the strait as soon as possible”.¹³⁸

As set out in the [Commons Library briefing on sanctions applied against Iran under the 2015 nuclear deal](#), China opposed the reimposition of sanctions against Iran under the snapback mechanism triggered by the UK, France and Germany in September 2025 (as did Russia). In 2026, it has called for the “unilateral sanctions [namely those from the US and others] on Iran [to] be removed at an early date”.¹³⁹

Russia welcomed the agreements of April and June 2026 and has called for a “comprehensive settlement”.¹⁴⁰ In addition to the reopening of the Strait of Hormuz, in June 2026 it said that Iran had the “legitimate right to develop and use nuclear energy for peaceful purposes”.¹⁴¹

In February 2026, Russia had also offered to take Iran’s enriched uranium as part of any political settlement, though Iran has uranium leaving the country.¹⁴²

¹³⁷ New York Times, [China pressed Iran toward cease-fire, Iranian officials say](#), 8 April 2026; China Diplomacy, [China calls for maintaining momentum of negotiations between US, Iran: FM](#), 1 July 2026

¹³⁸ China Foreign Affairs Ministry, [Five-Point Initiative of China and Pakistan](#), 31 March 2026

¹³⁹ China Mission to the UN, [Foreign Ministry spokesperson \[...\] regular press conference](#), 1 July 2026

¹⁴⁰ Reuters, [Russia says it welcomes Iran ceasefire, hopes US will now resume Ukraine talks](#), 8 April 2026; Russia Mission to the UN, [Statement by deputy permanent representative](#), 16 April 2026

¹⁴¹ Russia Foreign Affairs Ministry, [Foreign Affairs Ministry statement](#), 18 June 2026

¹⁴² Russia Foreign Affairs Ministry, [Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov’s interview](#), 5 February 2026

Appendix: Full text of the June 2026 Memorandum of Understanding

The text of the memorandum of understanding has not been officially released by Iran or the US. The text below is based on a readout to the media given by an US official and which has been checked against an English-language version published by the Iranian President. There are only minor differences, found in paragraphs 1 and 3.

Sources:

- CNN, “[US releases official agreement with Iran. Read the 14-point text](#)”, 17 June 2026
- BBC News, [US-Iran memorandum of understanding in full](#), 17 June 2026
- President Masoud Pezeshkian on Twitter/X, “[Memorandum of Understanding between Iran and the US](#)”, 18 June 2026

Islamabad Memorandum of Understanding between the US and Iran

The United States of America and the Islamic Republic of Iran have jointly agreed in good faith on [17 June 2026] on the following:

Termination of military operations on “all fronts”.

1 — The United States of America and the Islamic Republic of Iran and their allies in the current war are signing [by signing in the Iranian version] this MOU to declare the immediate and permanent termination of military operations on all fronts, including in Lebanon, and undertake from now on not to initiate any war or any military operation against each other, and to refrain from the threat or use of force against each other, and ensuring the territorial integrity and sovereignty of Lebanon. The final deal will confirm the permanent termination of the war on all fronts, including in Lebanon and other provisions of this paragraph.

Territorial integrity.

2 — The United States of America and the Islamic Republic of Iran undertake to respect each other’s sovereignty and territorial integrity and to refrain from interfering in each other’s internal affairs.

Initial 60-day negotiation period.

3 — The United States of America and the Islamic Republic of Iran commit to negotiating and achieving the final deal in maximum 60 days, extendable with mutual consent [the order of US/Iran is reversed in the Iranian version]

US to remove its naval blockade, Iran to allow ships to access Hormuz.

4 — Immediately upon the signing of this MOU, the United States of America will begin the removal of its naval blockade and any disturbances or impediments against the Islamic Republic of Iran, and will fully end the naval blockade within 30 days. During this period, the traffic of vessels will be in proportion to the numbers of pre-war traffic being restored by the Islamic Republic of Iran. The United States of America further undertakes to remove its forces from the proximity of the Islamic Republic of Iran within 30 days after the final deal.

Iran not to charge ships in Hormuz.

5 — Upon the signing of this MOU, the Islamic Republic of Iran will make arrangements using its best efforts for the safe passage of commercial vessels with no charge, for 60 days only, from the Persian Gulf to the Sea of Oman and vice versa. The traffic of commercial vessels will immediately start, and considering the need for removing the technical and military obstacles, and demining by the Islamic Republic of Iran will be instated within 30 days. The Islamic Republic of Iran will conduct dialog with the Sultanate of Oman to define the future administration and maritime services in the Strait of Hormuz in discussion with other Persian Gulf littoral states in line with the applicable international law and the sovereign rights of coastal states of the Strait of Hormuz.

US to develop US\$300 billion reconstruction plan for Iran.

6 — The United States of America undertakes with regional partners to develop a definitive, mutually agreed plan with at least USD 300 billion for the reconstruction and economic development of the Islamic Republic of Iran. The mechanism for the implementation of this plan will be finalized as part of a final deal within 60 days. All required licenses, waivers and permissions needed for the relevant financial transactions will be granted by the United States of America.

US to terminate all sanctions against Iran on a to-be-agreed schedule.

7 — The United States of America undertakes to terminate all types of sanctions against the Islamic Republic of Iran, including the United Nations Security Council resolutions, IAEA Board of Governors resolutions, and all unilateral US sanctions, primary and secondary, in an agreed upon schedule as part of the final deal. The Islamic Republic of Iran and the United States of America acknowledge the critical importance of the sanctions termination issue above mentioned, and expressed their intentions to immediately address these issues in the negotiations in order to achieve mutual agreement on them.

Iran will not develop or procure nuclear weapons and IAEA is to inspect removal of enriched uranium.

8 — The Islamic Republic of Iran reaffirms that it shall not procure or develop nuclear weapons. The United States of America and the Islamic Republic of Iran have agreed to resolve the disposition of stockpiled enriched material pursuant to a mechanism that will be mutually agreed upon in accordance with the schedule mentioned in paragraph seven, with the minimum methodology to be down blended on site under the supervision of the IAEA. The two parties also agreed to discuss the issue of enrichment and other mutually agreed matters related to the Islamic Republic of Iran's nuclear needs, based on a satisfactory framework being agreed upon in the final deal. The final deal will confirm the provisions of this paragraph. The United

States of America and the Islamic Republic of Iran acknowledge the critical importance of the nuclear issues above mentioned. They express their intention to immediately address these issues in the negotiations in order to achieve mutual agreement on them.

Maintaining the “status quo” during the MOU period.

9 — Pending the final deal, the United States of America and the Islamic Republic of Iran agree to maintain the status quo. The Islamic Republic of Iran will maintain the current status quo of its nuclear program, and the United States of America will not impose any new sanctions and will not deploy additional forces in the region.

US to issue waivers for Iranian oil exports.

10 — The United States of America undertakes that immediately upon the signing of this MOU and until the termination of sanctions, US Department of Treasury will issue waivers for the export of Iranian crude oil, petroleum products and derivatives, and all associated services, including banking transactions, insurances, transportation, etc.

US to make available frozen funds to Iran on a to-be-agreed plan.

11 — The United States of America undertakes to make fully available for use the frozen or restricted funds and assets of the Islamic Republic of Iran upon the implementation of this MOU. The United States of America and the Islamic Republic of Iran will mutually agree on the procedures related to the release of these funds during negotiations. Such funds, whether retained in the original account or transferred, shall be made fully usable for payment to any ultimate beneficiary designated by the Central Bank of the Islamic Republic of Iran. The United States of America undertakes to issue all necessary licenses and authorizations accordingly.

Monitoring mechanism.

12 — The United States of America and the Islamic Republic of Iran agree that an executive mechanism will be established to monitor the successful implementation of this MOU and the future compliance of the final deal.

Paragraphs 1,4,5,10 and 11 are to be implemented first.

13 — After signing this MOU, and subject to the beginning of the implementation of paragraphs 1, 4, 5, 10 and 11 of this MOU, and the continuing implementation of these measures, the United States of America and the Islamic Republic of Iran will start negotiations regarding the final deal exclusively on the other paragraphs.

The UN Security Council will endorse the final deal.

14 — The final deal will be endorsed by a binding UNSC resolution.

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